Start here: what danger?

01 / FIRST DECISION

One rule does not fit every emergency.

Fire or smoke INSIDE: use a safe exit, stay out; call verified local help. If trapped, give responders your location and access needs.

CO alarm: leave for fresh air and seek urgent medical help. Fuel-gas leak: avoid switches, flames and phones in the leak area; call local gas/emergency help from safety.

Fast-rising floodwater: move away from danger. Never walk or drive through floodwater.

Official radiation warning: go inside a substantial safe building, close outside openings and follow official updates. Do not make an unprompted journey through possible contamination.

Chemical release OUTSIDE: follow local shelter or evacuation directions; temporary sealing is not gas-proof. Chemical release INSIDE: reach clean air by a safe route.

STOP: Do not stay in fire, smoke, CO or leaking fuel gas because of an outside shelter alert. Report both hazards. Never improvise a safe route.

Evidence: P01–P03, S125–S129

The first ten minutes

02 / PEOPLE FIRST

Do only what makes the household safer.

1. Look: identify the immediate hazard, safe exit and any official alert.

2. Account: check children, people who need help, and pets only where safe.

3. Decide: safe shelter, safe exit, urgent care or emergency call. Do not collect a bag at the cost of escape.

4. Relay: check who missed an alert or needs it read, translated or signed. Use a second locally verified channel if safe.

5. Record: source, issue time and next check. Preserve phone battery, use safe light and keep exits clear.

STOP: No alert is not all-clear. Never re-enter a burning or smoke-filled building to retrieve supplies or animals.

Evidence: P01, P02, S116, S118, S123

Medical equipment + power

03 / PLAN BEFORE THE OUTAGE

A care register is not a medical backup supply.

POWER LOSS? CHECK THE PERSON

A / EMERGENCY HELP NOW

Life-sustaining support cannot be maintained, or the person is deteriorating.

B / STABLE? FOLLOW THE PLAN

Use only approved backup and written checks. Ask qualified help early if anything is uncertain.

NEVER GUESS SETTINGS, RUNTIME OR POWER.

If anyone relies on powered medical equipment, agree a written outage plan with their clinical team and device supplier. Include alarms, approved backup arrangements, contacts and when to seek help.

At power loss, check the person and prescribed support against the individual plan. Use only approved backup. Do not guess runtime, change settings or connect unapproved power.

STOP: If life-sustaining support cannot be maintained or the person deteriorates, activate verified local emergency help now. If stable but the plan or backup is uncertain, seek urgent qualified advice before support fails.

Evidence: P01, P04, S133

Feeding a baby safely

04 / PROTECT THE NEXT SAFE FEED

Start with the baby’s usual feeding plan.

Breastfeeding: continue where possible; seek skilled support if needed. Formula/prescribed feeds: do not substitute without clinical advice.

Four conditions: appropriate feed; verified safe water where needed; hygienic equipment; correct storage. Powdered formula is not sterile. Follow local qualified guidance and the product label.

Appropriate ready-to-feed formula may avoid powder mixing, but does not make equipment safe or replace a specialist prescribed feed. If a condition fails, seek qualified feeding help promptly; serious illness needs emergency care.

NO SAFE HOUSEHOLD SUBSTITUTE: no DIY formula, dilution, guessed temperature, unsafe water or improvised sterilising chemicals. Food-fridge timers do not clear baby feeds.

Evidence: P05, P06, S95, S100-S102, S134

Water: count + check

05 / DRINKING SUPPLY

Check the hazard before choosing any treatment.

Count uses: drinking, food, infant feeds, hand hygiene and care may need different safe supplies. WHO’s 15 L/person/day is a humanitarian basic-needs planning benchmark, not a household ration. Arrange accessible resupply.

Label each supply: VERIFIED for a specified use only with a reliable source and check time; otherwise RESTRICTED or UNKNOWN. Keep drinking supplies separate from water reserved for cleaning or flushing.

Germs: approved boiling or disinfection may help only when the hazard and local instructions support it. Never guess chemical amounts.

Fuel / chemicals / radioactivity: boiling does not remove these hazards. A household filter or disinfectant is not a universal clearance method. For radioactive incidents, permitted uses may differ: follow incident-specific officials.

STOP: Unknown or suspected toxic water is not cleared by smell, taste or boiling. No safe household substitute can be promised. Obtain verified safe water; follow the exact local notice.

Evidence: S119–S120, C074-01, C074-02; local authority

Food, feeds + medicines

06 / THREE SEPARATE DECISIONS

First check the person. Record unknown conditions as UNKNOWN.

URGENT PERSON FIRST: if someone is seriously unwell or life-sustaining prescribed support fails, seek locally verified emergency care now. Do not wait for a fridge verdict.

1 / FOOD: note outage time and measured temperatures or UNKNOWN. Keep doors shut where practical; use current local food-safety guidance. Never taste-test to judge safety.

2 / INFANT FEEDS: follow the baby’s established feeding plan and feed-specific storage instructions. A food timer cannot clear a feed. Seek trained help before the next safe feed is uncertain.

3 / MEDICINES + DEVICES: note the next prescribed treatment, exact product and status (unopened, in use, pump or reconstituted), measured conditions or UNKNOWN, and approved backup. Ask a qualified professional early.

STOP: Never use a food timer or generic insulin limit to clear medicine. No DIY formula, dose change, unapproved device power or direct contact with frozen ice packs.

Evidence: S101, S104–S106, S133–S139; verified local guidance

Toilets + hygiene

07 / WATER OR SEWER FAILURE

Dry tap, sewage backup and water warnings are different.

Dry tap: conserve safe water. Check with the local service before flushing; dry taps do not prove drains are safe.

Sewage backup / flooded toilet: stop using affected fixtures; keep children, food and drinking water away. Seek site or sanitation help.

Water warning: follow the exact restriction for drinking, washing and cleaning. Boiling does not remove toxic chemicals or radioactivity.

Flood-exposed food: discard food touched by floodwater and non-waterproof packages. Do not salvage a package unless the local food-safety authority explicitly permits its type and provides a safe procedure. Do not taste-test.

Hands: use soap and safe water after toilet or nappy care and before preparing food. Sanitiser does not replace washing visibly soiled hands.

No usable toilet: seek a safe, accessible maintained facility or authorised emergency arrangement. Temporary containment is not treatment; collection and disposal need local approval.

STOP: Do not empty waste into floodwater, improvise burial or put contained sewage into ordinary rubbish without authorisation. Do not mix cleaning chemicals.

Evidence: G206–G210, W074-01, C074-01/02; local service

Heat, cold + CO

08 / CLIMATE-FIRST BLACKOUT

Protect people from heat or cold; keep exits safe.

COLD: use dry layers and blankets; keep required ventilation clear. Seek safe warmth early if a vulnerable person is at risk.

HOT: shade the room, reduce exertion, use safe water and appropriate cooling. Seek an accessible cooler place if the home is unsafe.

CO: cannot be smelled. If an alarm sounds or exposure is suspected, get into fresh air and seek urgent local medical help. A CO-only alarm does not detect a fuel-gas leak. Severe confusion or collapse needs emergency care.

NEVER: run generators, grills or camping stoves inside, in garages or partly enclosed spaces. No fan or room-temperature number guarantees safety.

Evidence: S107–S110, S125, S132; local authorities

First aid: act + call

09 / WHEN SOMEONE IS HURT

Scene safety and early local emergency help come first.

Do not enter fire, floodwater, traffic or fumes to help. For immediate danger call your locally verified emergency service and follow the call handler.

Heavy bleeding: if safe, apply firm continuous direct pressure with a clean cloth or dressing while summoning emergency help. Do not remove embedded objects; follow trained/local guidance.

Thermal burns: cool promptly with suitable cool clean running water where available; protect the rest of the person from becoming cold. Remove nearby jewellery or clothing only if not stuck. Follow current locally approved first-aid guidance for duration, covering and clinical assessment.

STOP: no ice, butter, untrained invasive care, chemical neutralisation or contaminated water. Severe, chemical and electrical burns need emergency assessment.

Evidence: S97, S103

Local help + family contact

10 / VERIFY BEFORE YOU NEED IT

Emergency numbers and alerts differ worldwide.

Before an emergency: verify local emergency numbers and official alerts. Write numbers below; keep an offline copy and recheck when travelling.

Emergency / rescue (verified locally):

_____

Medical / poison help (where available):

_____

Local services / community help (if used):

_____

When warned: follow verified local instructions for the specific hazard. If in immediate danger, do not delay protective action to cross-check a message.

Accessible relay: check device support and any registration for calls, texts or alerts. Agree an offline relay for anyone who may miss warnings.

Separated family: use your safe contact plan. Where available, ask verified authorities or Red Cross/Red Crescent family-links services. Do not enter danger or publicly share a child’s location.

STOP: Calls and alerts may fail if devices, networks or power fail. No alert does not mean safe. Never enter danger to reunite.

Evidence: S112–S118, S123; local authorities

My household card

11 / WRITE IN PENCIL

Photocopy this page. Keep personal details secure.

Household / address: _____

Emergency contact: _____

Backup contact: _____

Meeting point: _____

School / care contact: _____

Medicine list / storage plan: _____

Medical-device plan location: _____

Device supplier / care team: _____

Safe water stored: _____ litres

Plan reviewed on: _____

BEFORE A BLACKOUT: Complete device-specific backup, alarm and escalation instructions with your clinical team; do not invent them here.

Evidence: P01, P04, S133

Source key + proof status

12 / READ BEFORE RELYING

Short source key; full URLs and claim notes are in the editable evidence register.

GLOBAL: WHO emergency sanitation technical note (W074-01); options require local waste services.

GLOBAL: WHO emergency water supply benchmarks and disaster risks (S119–S120; who.int).

WATER: CDC emergency water (C074-01) and radiation-water (C074-02); US technical examples, not global rules.

INFANT: UNICEF feeding in emergencies (unicef.org).

GLOBAL: IFRC first-aid guidelines 2025 (released March 2026); local clinical adaptation needed.

REGIONAL: UK FSA food cold-chain examples; not global.

CHEMICAL: WHO chemical-release information note (2017).

NO SAFE SUBSTITUTE: for unknown toxic/radiological drinking-water contamination; follow local officials.

DEVICE: US FDA device disaster advice; technical reference, not global law.

CARE: WHO prehospital emergency-care systems guidance (2025).

CLIMATE: WHO heat and housing health guidance (S107–S110).

CONTACTS: IFRC family plans; UNDRR inclusive warnings; ICRC family links (S112–S116).

NOT APPROVED: Editorial proof only. Independent clinical, emergency-management, accessibility and print review are still required. Current official advice overrides this draft.

Evidence: P01–P12 (legacy regional register); current source notes accompany this proof.